
“I do not despond and will not shrink from the task imposed upon me.”

JEFFERSON DAVIS IN A LETTER TO HIS WIFE, FEBRUARY 20, 1861

Jefferson Davis had considerable talents, including a deep and thorough knowledge of military affairs. However, his personality and temperament poisoned his relations with some of his generals and helped doom the Confederate war effort.

Davis's prewar record seemed to suit him far better for the role of a wartime commander-in-chief than his Northern counterpart, Abraham Lincoln. While Lincoln mocked his own brief stint as a militia officer, Davis had commanded a regiment with distinction in the War with Mexico. Later, Davis served as an effective reformist Secretary of War. He supervised the adoption of the rifle-musket and new infantry tactics to accompany this important change. However, at the War Department, Davis also showed his difficult personality in his bitter rows with General-in-Chief Winfield Scott.

Davis's contentious personality had been apparent even at West Point, which nearly expelled him for disciplinary reasons. These traits also led to his army court martial in 1835 for insubordination. After the trial, Davis resigned his commission and embarked on a life in politics.

Before he joined President Pierce's administration as Secretary of War, Davis had served as U.S. senator for Mississippi, where he earned a reputation as a Southern radical. He opposed the Compromise of 1850, which helped lead to his defeat in the 1851 gubernatorial election in Mississippi. Davis reentered the Senate in 1857, where he charted a more moderate course. During the secession winter after Lincoln's election to the presidency, he even